Combat rule – Reactions · SRD 5.2.1

A **Reaction** is an **instant** response to a trigger. You get **one per round**, refreshed at the **start of your turn**. You can use it on someone else's turn… or on your own.

Examples: Opportunity Attack, a readied action, a spell like *Shield* or *Counterspell*.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. **One Reaction** per round.
2. It returns at the **start of your turn**.
3. It needs a defined **trigger**.
4. Opportunity Attack: a Reaction for **every creature**.

⚠ Change from 2014

SRD 2024 clarifies you can use your Reaction even on your own turn, after an action or a bonus action.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The SRD doesn't say what happens when two triggers occur together. Fix: you pick one Reaction; the other is lost.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can pause an enemy's narration to ask "Does anyone want to react?".

Step 1 – Spot the trigger:

A specific event happens (an enemy leaves your reach, a spell targets you).

Step 2 – Check:

Do you still have your Reaction? Can you perceive the trigger?

Step 3 – Interrupt:

Your response happens **right after** the trigger (unless the text says "before").

Step 4 – Resolve:

You act, then play resumes where it was.

Step 5 – Note it:

You can't react again until the **start of your next turn**.

Example: Brann uses Shield as a Reaction against an arrow, then regains his Reaction at the start of his turn.

⚠ Common questions:

How many Reactions per round?

Just one.

When does it refresh?

At the start of your turn.

Can I react on my own turn?

Yes, if a trigger exists.

Is a Reaction an action?

No, it's a separate category.

Must I see the trigger?

You must be able to perceive it.

Is an Opportunity Attack mandatory?

No, you choose whether to act.

⚠ Debate points and table options: Table rule

Surprise

Can a surprised character react? **Option**: yes from round 1.

Cancelled trigger

If the trigger vanishes, is the Reaction lost? **Option**: no.

Several Reactions

Some feats grant more. **Option**: max 2 per round.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Turn start

The Reaction returns at the start of your turn, not the end.

Reaction spells

They have a trigger written in their casting time.

Opportunity Attack

See the dedicated sheet.

These points remain open to discussion: your feedback is welcome to refine this sheet.

Notices: This work includes material from the System Reference Document 5.2.1 ("SRD 5.2.1") by Wizards of the Coast LLC, available at https://www.dndbeyond.com/srd. The SRD 5.2.1 is licensed under the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International License, available at https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/legalcode. Unofficial sheet, 5E compatible (2024 rules), neither approved nor sponsored by Wizards of the Coast. Rules come from SRD 5.2.1; where the SRD gives no answer, explanations rely on our own interpretation. The "Table rule" parts are the author's own creations. Borders, banner, texture, titles, layout, table rules and examples: © Jaja, all rights reserved. Sources: SRD 5.2.1 (official English version); rule clarifications cross-checked with answers found on the web and reworded; numeric examples are invented; last revised: November 2026. Fonts: TeX Gyre Pagella (GUST), DejaVu Sans, Noto Color Emoji (OFL).